



Ministry of Education

Identified Competency Focus Areas and Core Courses for Ethiopian Higher Education Institutions' Exit Examination

**Program: Bachelor of Science in Comprehensive Nursing
and
Bachelor of Science in Nursing**

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1. Introduction

In the modern world, experts place a strong focus on the value and contribution human resources provide to national development. They also hold that each organization's human capital is its most valuable asset. In this respect, nurses are taken into account as the biggest and the most important human resource in healthcare organizations.

Due to rapid advancements in science and technology and a lack to cope with it, there has been a concern towards competency in nursing profession. Additionally, modern perspectives on professionalism highlight that all medical professions, particularly nurses, have an ethical and professional duty to improve the quality of the healthcare system. As a result, they ought to have a dedication to professionalism and raise the standard of care.

It has been suggested that a key component of providing standard nursing care is through professional expertise. And, having competency leads to an improved quality of patient care and an increased patient satisfaction and helps to promote nursing as a profession and improve nursing education. This expectation must be met by producing competent graduates who can deliver high-quality and standardized nursing care.

Thus, implementing national exit examination for Comprehensive nursing graduates will have a great implication in producing competent citizens in knowledge, skill, and attitude.

Moreover, there should be an intervention strategy to evaluate whether graduates have attained the required competencies with the desired knowledge, skill, and attitude through a comprehensive assessment of learning. So, implementing an exit exam as an intervention strategy helps to check whether students have achieved the desired level of competency and learning outcome. Hence, competence-based comprehensive examination/s are conducted upon the completion of the graduate program.

In this regard, the Ministry of Education (hereafter MoE) has been working on a strategy to implement national exit examination for undergraduate programs beginning from the 2015 E.C (2022/23 G.C).

❖ Objectives of the Exit Exam

The Main Objectives of Exit Examination are as follows:

- To ensure students' achievement and improve the quality of education;
- To improve the relevance of academic programs and institutional performance;
- To assess whether higher education graduates attain the graduate profile or not
- To produce skilled and competent manpower for local, national, and international markets;
- To ensure that graduates achieve the required learning outcomes and hence meet the graduate profile of the curriculum;
- To provide a platform as a quality monitoring tool in the form of certification of competence for employment;

❖ Significance of the Document

It is important to set competency areas of the subject matter (program) in order to measure how much graduates are acquired skills, knowledge, and attitudes. The following shows us the **significance of setting competencies** and identifying selected courses of the program;

- To set competencies that helps to assess the basic skills, knowledge and attitude of graduating students,
- To systematically identify the core courses which will be included in the exit exam, and
- To realize standardization of higher education programs and to be able to meet minimum quality standards across all programs

2. Expected Profiles of Graduates

A graduate's profile is the general description of the desirable qualities of graduates in real-world work. Graduates' profile helps to determine the students' conceptual knowledge, skills, and attitude that they possess. A graduate profile can be advanced through experience in the real world. Graduates in Bachelor of Science in Comprehensive Nursing will apply the concepts and models of disease prevention and health promotion in health care service provision; analyze, interpret and use health and health-related indicators. Additionally, graduate of BSc nurses are expected to apply methods of nutritional assessment, interpret results and intervene accordingly, apply principles of public emergency and disaster management, provide basic holistic care for individuals, families,

and communities at large of all age groups in a variety of health care settings using the nursing process as a framework.

Similarly they are expected to conduct complete patient assessment, use critical thinking to analyze and interpret health data, establish priorities and make the appropriate decision, diagnose the client's health needs and responses to the actual or potential health conditions, plan appropriate independent and collaborative nursing interventions, identify and manage client and evaluate the outcomes by using Gordon approach/other relevant tools.

Furthermore, they should perform basic and advanced nursing procedures, assist advanced diagnostic and therapeutic procedures using the latest evidence, engage in preventive, promotive, curative, and rehabilitative care for clients. They should also record, document and report patient and health related data; work collaboratively and effectively with other health workers; guide, counsel, and teach clients based on their need in all health settings including the community; perform activities in prevention (including counseling), control, and management of emerging and re-emerging communicable and non-communicable diseases. Again, diagnose and manage communicable and non-communicable diseases.

Moreover, they will be able to provide comprehensive maternal and child health care services; assess and manage clients with special needs; provide comprehensive mental health nursing care; manage common emergency and acute health problems; apply professional, ethical, and legal standards and codes in nursing practice; implement quality improvement measures and maintain a safe patient environment; practice effective therapeutic communication; apply informatics and technology for health data management and patient care; utilize evidences for patient health care services; maintain and practice updated nursing care standards; exercise leadership and involve in the management of the health care system; provide community health nursing services; maintain personal effectiveness and engage in continuous professional development, and be nurse educator.

3. Competences and Learning Outcomes

3.1. Competences

Currently, the competency of students will be measured by national exit examination at the end of completion of nursing courses with a great emphasis on students' knowledge, skill, and attitude. The details of the competency are presented below by categorizing knowledge, skills, and attitudes.

Areas of Competency	Expected Competencies to be achieved
Knowledge	Graduates will be able to • Understand nursing plan of care based on prioritized client problem through analysing patient assessment information. • Know different professional ethical principles and theories to make sound decision related to nursing care delivery. • Acquire the concept of planning, implementation, and evaluation of health promotion, disease prevention, and health protection programs and services within the community. • Recognize the major concepts of communication for proper interaction and education of clients. • Understand effective managerial and leadership skills in the provision of quality nursing care. • Acquire the basic concepts of research methods to investigate health problems at as it applies to nursing to the improve quality of care, promote the health status of patients and families. • Be aware to use information technology for better application in nursing and health care.
Skills	• Provide holistic nursing care through direct interaction with patients, families, and groups of patients to promote health or well-being and improve quality of life.

Areas of Competency	Expected Competencies to be achieved
	• Provide comprehensive nursing care and management for new-borns, children • Provide standardized, compassionate and respectful Nursing care for women and their foetus during labour and delivery. • Conduct complete mental health assessment and provide mental health services at institutional and community settings. • Apply the acquired knowledge from social, behavioural, and public health sciences and provide appropriate health services to clients from different backgrounds and in all age groups. • Demonstrate empathic communication skills and techniques for effective interpersonal relationships with clients and other Professionals in health care settings. • Work as a team leader, change agent, patient advocator, planner, and mentor for the wellbeing, rapid recovery, independence, and safety of clients through efficient use of scarce resources. • Actively engage in scientific research activities, interpretation, and application of evidence in clinical practice and quality improvement interventions. • Participate in educational and continuing professional development activities to maintain competency and quality in area of practice. • Apply the concept of mentorship and coaching for professional development.
Attitudes	• Appreciate individuals' preferences, values, and needs, and respect the client as a full partner in providing coordinated, age and culturally-appropriate, compassionate, respectful, safe, and effective care. • Preserve professionalism through ethical and legal practices by demonstrating standardized nursing care that is consistent with

Areas of Competency	Expected Competencies to be achieved
	moral, altruistic, legal, ethical, regulatory, and humanistic principles. Promote and maintain the professional role of the nurse by upholding the professional Code for Nurses.

3.2. Learning Outcomes

- Apply the concepts and models of disease prevention and health promotion
- Apply methods of nutritional assessment, interpret results and provide nutritional counseling and education
- Demonstrate the ability to promote the health of populations by influencing lifestyle, nutrition, and socio-economic, physical, and cultural environment through methods of health promotion, including health education, directed towards populations, communities, and individuals
- Apply principles of diversity and provide culturally relevant service to all age groups
- Perform holistic nursing practices about current patient care information, professional practice standards, guidelines, rules, and regulations
- Provide a rationale for decisions and actions in matters related to the provision of care for clients
- Manage teamwork and collaborative performances across an array of functions
- Apply evidence-based nursing knowledge in the provision of care for the client
- Document accurately and timely relevant health care data to ensure patient safety and improve health outcome
- Serve as a role model, change agent, teacher, and mentor in their professional life
- Participate in ethical decision-making within the multidisciplinary team
- Take responsibility and accountability for own decisions, actions, or omissions in nursing care delivery
- Adhere to all relevant ethical codes of conduct and standards set by the profession, including, but not limited to, confidentiality, privacy, and respect for the dignity
- Advocate for maintaining a standard of care and evidence-based practice

- Protect clients from incompetent, unethical, or illegal healthcare practices, and unconsented research endeavors
- Maintain patients' bill of rights throughout nursing care service including, but not limited to, guidance informed choice, and consent
- Apply compassionate and respectful nursing care
- Practices within a prescribed legal framework relevant to own practice, including but not limited to, the Constitution, the Children's Act, Nursing Act, National Health Act Report any malpractices, tort, and criminal acts to the responsible body
- Assess, diagnose, plan and manage client problems, and evaluate outcomes using the nursing process as a framework
- Anticipate and manage potential complications and collaborative problems of clients
- Manage common emergency, acute & chronic health problems accordingly
- Perform basic nursing procedures correctly and independently
- Assist advanced diagnostic and therapeutic procedures applied for clients undergoing medical or surgical care
- Perform preventive, promotive, curative, and rehabilitative care for clients in all age groups
- Provide holistic maternal, newborn, child, adolescent, and geriatric care
- Take history and collects relevant health data from clients or significant others
- Performs comprehensive physical examinations to identify physical, mental, or emotional problems of the client
- Analyze and interpret health data through the functional health pattern (Gordon's) approach
- Documents and report findings with the patient, the patient family (when appropriate), and the multidisciplinary team promptly
- Work collaboratively with other health workers to help solicit client information
- Analyses and utilizes assessment information to make a clinical judgment about the clients' status and responses to actual or potential health conditions.
- Utilizes expert knowledge to interpret results of screenings and diagnostic investigations performed
- Formulates nursing and/or medical diagnosis

- Make prioritization of clients' problem
- Identify and document expected outcomes and goals
- Develop a prioritized plan of care that includes interventions and alternatives to attain expected outcomes for the client
- Reviews and revises the plan with the client, the client's family, and the multidisciplinary team
- Considers economic, social, religious, cultural, and environmental conditions of the clients during the designing of the nursing plan of care
- Implements the interventions identified in the plan of care in-line with evidence-based nursing practice
- Collaborates with nursing colleagues and other members of the healthcare team to implement the plan of care
- Implement the plan of care with efficient utilization of resources
- Integrates principles of safety and quality into interventions
- Documents implementation of the identified plan accordingly
- Evaluate patient outcomes against stated goals and outcome criteria
- Monitor progress of client status and adjust nursing care plan accordingly
- Collaborate with clients, their families, and the healthcare team in the evaluation process
- Document all processes and outcomes, and keep them confidential
- Communicate effectively both verbally and/or non-verbally in the patient care environment
- Practice proper recording and documentation of patient care-related information and other relevant data produced in their practice environment
- Demonstrate effective communication with clients/patients, their families, the health care team, and the community at large
- Forge seamless collaboration and partnership with people within and outside of the health organizations
- Utilize information, education, and communication (IEC) and behavior change communication (BCC) materials for proper communication and education of clients
- Apply therapeutic communication skills in the management of client
- Communicate appropriately in special circumstances and sensitive issues
- Provide counseling services for clients based on their scope

- Employ continuous and sustainable quality improvement mechanisms to improve client outcomes and transform future nursing practices
- Take responsibility for managing and leading health programs at all levels of the managerial hierarchy
- Play a team lead role and model professionalism to peers and other colleagues in the public health landscape
- Manage time and resources effectively and efficiently to ensure the nursing quality of care is maintained and the client's outcome improved
- Apply principles of leadership in the management of clinical care and utilization of resources
- Advocate for a safe working environment for nursing and medical care provision
- Participate in the development and implementation of standards, practice guidelines, policies, and protocol
- Apply management and leadership theories in the execution of nursing care and delegation of responsibilities
- Attain continuous professional and personal development
- Search, collect, organize and interpret health and biomedical information from different databases
- Retrieve and use patient-specific information from a clinical data system by maintaining confidentiality and protection of individual data
- Formulate hypotheses, collect and critically evaluate data to find a solution for the problems, and disseminate findings.
- Identify knowledge and performance gaps that can be solved by using systematic methods
- Use information technology and application systems to manage research data and navigate to access online information and literature
- Advocate for keeping patients' rights during research activities
- Utilize updated nursing research findings for evidence-based nursing practice and quality improvement interventions
- Participate in critical appraisal of research findings and scholarly activities
- Acquires current knowledge and skills that reflect evidence-based practice and applies them appropriately in a practice setting

- Evaluates own nursing knowledge and practice about current patient care information professional practice standards, guidelines, and rules and regulations
- Possess professional excellence and competence through continuing education and lifelong learning
- Apply principles of teaching, learning, and evaluation to design educational programs that enhance the knowledge and practice of staff in the different care unit
- Participates in formal and informal education of others
- Teach nursing students at college, university, and health facility level
- Involve in curriculum design and implementation process
- Demonstrate pedagogic skills in education, and assessment
- Promote professionalism and continuous professional development
- Demonstrates commitment to the personal and professional development of self and others.

4. Categorizing Courses of the Program into Themes

The graduates' competencies and learning outcomes of the comprehensive nursing program are assessed with the following Five major thematic areas.

Themes	List of themes in the comprehensive nursing program
Theme 1	Patient Care
Theme 2	Professionalism
Theme 3	Scholarly
Theme 4	Nursing Leadership and management
Theme 5	Health Promotion and disease prevention

5. Modules/courses to be included in the Exit Examination

This document has been compiled with **five themes** and **13 modules/ courses** for exit examination for achieving the competencies level of graduates that are expected to acquire. According to the direction suggested by the head of quality and competency improvement desk (at MoE), during the preparation of this document, there was a general consensus that a specific program should

consider a total of **13 lists of modules/courses**. In Comprehensive nursing program there is plenty number of modules/courses that were prescribed in sequences like part I and part II; but the core modules/courses are clearly presented and have been selected in this document. Accordingly, this exit examination document has identified **13 modules/courses** delivered at different semesters and academic calendars. The details of these modules/course are stated in below table.

S. No	List of Themes	List of Module/Course	Module /Course/ Code	ECTS	Cr.hr	% share
1	Patient Care	Foundation of Nursing I	NursM-1033	7	6	6
		Foundation of Nursing II	NursM_2043	13	11	11
		Medical-Surgical Nursing I	NursM_2073	18	15	15
		Medical-Surgical II	NursM_3013	22	18	18
		Pediatric and child health nursing	NursM_3033	13	11	11
		Maternity and Reproductive health nursing	NursM_3023	14	11	11
		Mental Health Nursing	NursM-3053	8	7	7
2	Professionalism	Nursing Professional Ethics	NursM-1033	1.65	1	1
		Nursing Education and curriculum development	NursM-3042	3	2	2
3	Scholarly	Nursing Research Methods	NursM_4032	5	4	4
		Measurement of Health and disease	SPHM-2062	7	6	6
4	Nursing Leadership and management	Nursing Leadership and management	NursM-4022	7	6	6
5	Health Promotion and disease prevention	Health Promotion and disease prevention	SPHM_2052	5	4	4
Total		13 Course		123.65	75	100

6. Conclusion

Comprehensive nurses utilize evidence-based nursing knowledge and professional nursing judgment to assess health needs, provide nursing care, educate clients and support individuals to manage their health holistically. They practice in collaboration with other healthcare professionals.

Generally, the basic aim of the national exit examination is to produce high-level and qualified professionals in nursing that will benefit the country's health sector. The national exit examination offers a comprehensive basis for graduates' careers and further education in nursing on the identified modules/course lists and themes. Nursing competency is a core ability that is required for fulfilling nursing responsibilities. Therefore, it is important to clearly define nursing competency in order to establish a foundation for nursing education curriculum.

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